

University of Waterloo: Conrad Grebel College

MUSIC 246: Soundtracks

Fall 2026

Instructor: Simon Wood

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Course Objective: Music 246 is a historical and aesthetic survey of the styles, trends, and important figures in the development of narrative film music, from the invention of moving pictures to the present day. The course will also include a discussion of the technical process of creating film music, as well as a review of the role of popular music in film.

Required Texts:

Roger Hickman, Reel Music: Exploring 100 Years of Film Music: 2nd Edition (New York: WW Norton, 2017).

A digital version of the textbook may be obtained through the link on our Learn webpage, or through the following link:

Digital (Vitalsource) : ISBN 9780393622904

<https://uwaterloo-store.vitalsource.com/products/reel-music-exploring-100-years-of-film-music-roger-hickman-v9780393622904>

180-day subscription - \$45.07 / Lifetime subscription - \$71.75

Methods of Evaluation:

Assessment	Weighting	Date
Term Test 1	25%	Thursday October 8 th at 7:00 pm
Term Test 2	25%	Thursday November 5 th at 7:00 pm
Examination	50%	TBA-During the December Exam Period

Term Tests and Exam:

The tests and exam will be in multiple-choice format. The tests and the exam are NOT cumulative. The duration of the term tests is 50 minutes. The duration of the final exam is 2.5 hours. **IF YOU MISS A TEST, SUBMIT YOUR VIF TO YOUR DEPARTMENT AND PLEASE NOTIFY ME IMMEDIATELY.**

Deferred tests will be written one week after the original test date.

NOTE: During tests and exams students may not have any type of smart electronic device in their possession (including, but not limited to phones, smart watches, etc.) These devices must be placed in your book bags and left at the front of the testing room. Students who are found to have such a device in their possession during a test or exam may face academic penalty. Also, Smart Glasses are particularly creepy and should never be used.

Illness: This class will follow the Faculty of Arts policy on Accommodations for Illness or Extenuating Circumstances. **If you become ill and are unable to attend a term test, please ensure that you upload your VIF (Verification of Illness Form) to your department's webpage.** Do not send your VIF to me. Deferred tests will NOT be granted without the submission of a VIF. If a student misses an in-person lecture due to illness, they should acquire a copy of the class notes from a classmate, review the notes, then make an appointment to see me to review any aspects of the lecture that are not clear.

Viewing:

Students must view one film every week, as indicated in the Course Schedule. Questions will be posted on the course web site that will act as a guide to your viewing. **Most** of these films can be found through online streaming services.

As a UW student, you have access to the Criterion Collection, and excellent online collection of hundreds of films. Most of the films we will be watching this term can be accessed through this site.

On campus you should be able to link to the site through the following:

<https://www.criterionondemand.com/>

Off campus you need to connect using this link and enter your last name and WatCard barcode number:

<https://proxy.lib.uwaterloo.ca/login?url=https://www.criterionondemand.com/>

Web Page: This course will make use of a WATERLOO LEARN website. This site will provide general information for the course, study guides and grades for term tests. Important announcements such as the cancellation of class due to illness will also be posted there, so please try to check the site before each class, just in case.

General Faculty and University Policy:

Academic Integrity

Academic Integrity: In order to maintain a culture of academic integrity, members of the University of Waterloo are expected to promote honesty, trust, fairness, respect and responsibility.

Discipline: A student is expected to know what constitutes academic integrity, to avoid committing academic offences, and to take responsibility for his/her actions. A student who is unsure whether an action constitutes an offence, or who needs help in learning how to avoid offences (e.g., plagiarism, cheating) or about “rules” for group work/collaboration should seek guidance from the course professor, academic advisor, or the Undergraduate Associate Dean. When misconduct has been found to have occurred, disciplinary penalties will be imposed under Policy 71 – Student Discipline. For information on categories of offenses and types of penalties, students should refer to Policy 71 - Student Discipline.

Grievance: A student who believes that a decision affecting some aspect of his/her university life has been unfair or unreasonable may have grounds for initiating a grievance. Read Policy 70 - Student Petitions and Grievances, Section 4.

Appeals: A student may appeal the finding and/or penalty in a decision made under Policy 70 - Student Petitions and Grievances (other than regarding a petition) or Policy 71 - Student Discipline if a ground for an appeal can be established. Read Policy 72 - Student Appeals.

Other sources of information for students:

Academic Integrity website (Arts)

Academic Integrity Office (UWaterloo)

Accommodation for Students with Disabilities

Note for students with disabilities: The AccessAbility Services office, located in Needles Hall Room 1132, collaborates with all academic departments to arrange appropriate accommodations for students with disabilities without compromising the academic integrity of the curriculum. If you require academic accommodations to lessen the impact of your disability, please register with the AS office at the beginning of each academic term.

Course Outline:

Course topics, Viewing Assignments and readings:

Week 1, 2, and 3: Course Introduction, What to Listen For in Film / Technical Details / How It's Done / The Silent Era

Reading: Chapters 1-6

Week 4: The Birth of Sound:

Reading: Chapters 9 and 10

Week 5: The Golden Age Of Hollywood:

Viewing: *The Adventures of Robin Hood* (1938)

Reading: Chapters 9 and 10

Week 6: The 1940s: Viewing: *Laura* (1944)

Readings: Chapter 11 to 13

Week 7: The 1950s and Hitchcock/Herrmann:

Viewing: *Psycho* (1960) Readings: Chapters 14 and 15

Week 8: The 1960s/Goldsmith:

Viewing: *Planet of the Apes* (1968)

Readings: Chapters 17 and 18

Week 9: The 1970s/Williams: Viewing: *Jaws* (1975)

Readings: Chapters 19 to 21

Week 10: The 1980s/Horner:

Viewing: *Star Trek II: The Wrath of Khan* (1982)

Readings: Chapters 23 to 25

Week 11: The 90s:

Viewing: *Edward Scissorhands* (1990)

Reading: Chapters 22 and 27

Week 12: Current Trends:

Viewing: *Inception* (2010)

Reading: Chapters 26, 29 and 30